Elvis of Nazareth

By Jay Huling

INTRODUCTION

The yet-to-be-discovered Elvis Presley has an inexplicable foreknowledge of his future life events. As he waits to make a personal recording for his mama's birthday at Sun Record's famed Memphis Recording Studio, he ponders the meaning of his life. And he's torn between making the record or traveling down another road. -- Whether it's "hunka hunk burning love" or a burning bush. To his rescue come historic figures from the Bible -- Moses, King Solomon, a Roman centurion, and Jesus himself. Elvis of Nazareth by Jay Huling.

[THE YOUNG ELVIS about as nervous as a man can get, is seated on a long couch in the receptionist area. A sign above his head reads: "Memphis Recording Studio. Make Your Own Personal Records." He fidgets with his gum]

ELVIS: I'm gonna record a song for my mama. Kind of a present.

MARION: That's nice. *[She tries to continue her work, but Elvis starts fidgeting again. She stares him down.]*

ELVIS: Sorry ... Mr. Phillips is gonna discover me and not give you any of the credit.

MARION: I beg your pardon?

ELVIS: They're gonna call me the King.

MARION: Look, I want credit where credit is due. What am I not getting credit for?

ELVIS: I'm gonna record a song for my mama. Kind of a present. You're gonna discover me; Mr. Phillips is gonna get the credit, and I'm gonna go on to be the king of roll and rock.

MARION: Roll and rock?

ELVIS: It's a little gospel and rhythm and blues thing I put together.

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MARION: Roll and rock doesn't quite "roll" off the tongue. Why don't you call it rock and roll? *[A buzzer sounds at the door. Marion presses a button on the intercom system at her desk.]* Come in! [*Moses, who's come directly from Mount Sinai, circa* 1225, *enters, staff in hand, and approaches Marion's desk.]* May I help you?

MOSES: Let my people go!

MARION: Let who go?

MOSES: Art thou deaf? Am I not enunciating my consonants? Let my people go!

MARION: If you could just have a seat, Mr. Phillips will be with you in a moment.

MOSES: So that ye may know that the Lord-the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob-hath sent me, this miraculous sign I now perform ... [*Moses throws down his staff, and it lands near Marion's desk with a thud. There is an awkward silence.]*

MARION: That was supposed to turn into a snake, wasn't it?

MOSES: Uh-huh.

MARION: Do you need a moment?

MOSES: 'Preciate it. *[He takes up his staff and ponders over it, perplexed as to why it didn't work.]*

ELVIS: You okay?

MOSES: I was told-cast down thy rod and it will become a serpent! Did you see me cast down my rod?

ELVIS: Yes.

MOSES: Did it become a serpent?

ELVIS: No. Pleasure to meet you. My name's Elvis.

MOSES: I am Moses, discovered by Pharaoh's daughter hidden in a basket among the reeds near the river's bank. I received my call from the great bush which burned-yet was not consumed. I have come to lead my people out

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from bondage.

ELVIS: I'm gonna record a song for my mama. Kind of a present.

MOSES: Honoring thy father and mother. That's good. I should write that down.

ELVIS: They're gonna put me on *The Ed Sullivan Show* and shoot me from the waist up. Won't be able to see me wiggle.

MOSES: Thou wiggles? Are you taking anything for that?

ELVIS: I do it on purpose. It's how I express the song.

MOSES: I always wanted to be a singer. Never worked out. The material I was given! *[Quoting.]* "The horse and his rider hath he thrown into the sea." *[Then.]* What can you do with that?

ELVIS: I never knew you wanted to be a singer. But your life's purpose is so extraordinary.

MOSES: I wandered in the desert for forty years. I was willing to stop and ask for directions-but no!

ELVIS: I've always wished for a higher calling.

MOSES: It ain't what it's cracked up to be. Trust me, kid, stick to singing and wiggling.

ELVIS: You don't understand. Somewhere deep inside me there's an empty space. What's it gonna take to fill that up? I gotta find something. I'm not sure gyratin' like a jackhammer is it.

MOSES: Thou must choose. The pleasures of sin for a season, or an eternity of never getting past second base.

ELVIS: But what is that compared to a life making disciples for the Kingdom?

MOSES: My son, I gotta do what I gotta do. You don't. Thou understandeth? Think about it. Excuse me. *[Crossing to Marion.]* Let me let you in on a little secret.

MOSES: Frogs. Big green juicy amphibians. On your bed, down your drawers, in your

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chicken potpie. Frogs the size of baseball mitts. Everywhere! Unless thou hearken unto me.

MARION: And you're telling me this because ... ?

MOSES: Because thus saith the Lord-LET MY PEOPLE GO!-that they may serve me.

MARION: Mr. Phillips is the only one who can approve such a request. [*Moses returns to his seat.]*

ELVIS: You okay?

MOSES: To tell you the truth, I knew it wouldn't work. Can't do something cool like make fire rain down from heaven. Gotta make locusts swarm! Ever seen a swarm of locusts? Looks like a flying blob of pork and beans coming smack at you.

ELVIS: [To Marion] I don't think I can go through with this.

MARION: You're not about to chicken out, are you? Mr. Phillips will be with you any moment. Your future is waiting.

ELVIS: You don't know what I know. They're gonna have me singing to a dog, man. Then I get drafted. And then come the Beatles.

MARION: The who?

ELVIS: No, not the Who, the Beatles.

MARION: Beetles and locusts. Why don't we just let the people go?

ELVIS: No-they're four lads from Liverpool. Lots of mediocre stuff that's hailed as genius.

MARION: Will I get any credit for them?

ELVIS: I should just go home. *[The door buzzer sounds again.]*

MARION: Come in! *[The door opens and King Solomon enters, in all his splendor. He approaches Marion*] May I help you?

SOLOMON: Behold, thou art fair, my beloved, yea, pleasant: also our bed is green.

MARION: Come again?

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SOLOMON: Thy two breasts are like two young roes that are twins, which feed among the lilies. Thou art all fair, my love; there is no spot in thee.

MARION That's really very sweet of you. But not very office appropriate. If you'll just have a seat, Mr. Phillips will be with you as soon as possible.

SOLOMON: For you, I will be a young stag upon the mountains of spices. [Solomon *turns and sits next to Elvis]* Gets 'em every time.

ELVIS: That was some smooth talking. My name's Elvis. It's a pleasure to meet you.

SOLOMON: I am Solomon, the third and last king of united Israel. The son of David, son of Jesse.

ELVIS: I had a twin brother named Jesse.

SOLOMON: I had some seven hundred wives and three hundred concubines.

ELVIS: I'm gonna earn more than a hundred and fifty gold records.

SOLOMON: Oh, yeah, well, I wrote three thousand proverbs.

ELVIS: I'm gonna sell more than a billion records worldwide.

SOLOMON: I have written more than one thousand songs. Including Song of Solomon- the greatest love song of all.

ELVIS: Did any of them go to number one?

SOLOMON: Art thou challenging me?

ELVIS: I just asked a question.

SOLOMON: [*takes some sheet music out of his pocket and hands it to Elvis.*) Hast thou anything as artful and lovely as this-?

ELVIS: *[Reading.)* "Except the Lord build the house, They labour in vain that build it: Except the Lord keep the city, The watchman waketh but in vain." [Elvis *pulls a piece of paper from his pocket and hands it to Solomon.*)

ELVIS: Try this on for size. From one of my movies.

SOLOMON: *[Reading.)* "I feel it in my leg, I feel it in my shoe, Tell me pretty baby,

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If you think you feel it too." *[Then.]* How profound. *[Handing Elvis more lyrics.]* But surely you are no match for me.

ELVIS: *[Reading.)* "It is vain for you to rise up early, To sit up late, To eat the bread of sorrows: For so he giveth his beloved sleep." *[Then.]* Well played. *[Handing lyrics to Solomon.*] But, as well as this-?

SOLOMON: *[Reading.]* "Some people like to rock, Some people like to roll, But movin' and a-groovin', Gonna satisfy my soul." *[Then.]* Satisfaction of soul? Intriguing. Thou art a worthy adversary. Wilt thou teach me to be artful in song as thou?

ELVIS: Me? Teach you? You have written some of the most beautiful verses of the holy Scriptures.

SOLOMON: But I want something different. I want a pop song!

ELVIS: And I want to be wise like you.

SOLOMON: Look, if you're talking about that cutting-the-baby-in-half thing-I was bluffing. I can't believe they fell for that baloney!

ELVIS: But your life as a man of God is so important.

SOLOMON: Ever heard of a King Solomon impersonator? Huh? No one's ever won a karaoke contest doing me.

ELVIS: I'm just not so sure it's right for me anymore.

SOLOMON: Thou fool. The only thing that is right is to fear God and keep his commandments. Now teach me to rock my fanny off. [Elvis *stands up, begins to demonstrate]*

ELVIS: You kinda got to let the rhythm ooze out of you.

SOLOMON: Showest thou me this ooze.

ELVIS: *[Shaking his leg in rhythm.]* This is ooze. With a beat. Four-four time. *[Snapping his fingers.]* Some people snap their fingers. *[Tapping his toe.]* Some people tap their toes. *[Swaying back and forth.]* And some people sway back

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and forth. I kinda put 'em all together, I guess. That's how the blues is born.

SOLOMON: *[Pleased.]* A time to be born. Yes.

ELVIS: Then you just rock till you drop.

SOLOMON: *[Writing something down.]* A time to be rocked. And a time to be dropped. I like this. It's almost like there's a time for every season under Heaven. Cease! A handful of quietness, please. *[Crossing to a chair on the other side of the room.]* I'm on a roll! And I'm not going to give you any of the credit. [Solomon *begins writing furiously.] [The door buzzer sounds again.]*

MARION: Come in! *[The door opens and a Roman Centurion enters with his prisoner; Jesus of Nazareth.*] May I help you?

CENTURION: Your Excellency, this man claims to be the Christ, the king of the Jews!

MARION: *[To Elvis.*] I thought you said you were the King.

ELVIS: No, I'm the king of roll and rock.

CENTURION: The people want him crucified.

MARION: His singing can't be that bad.

CENTURION: Not him! *[Pushing Jesus forward.]* Him!

MARION: *[To Jesus.*] Oh. I'm sorry, what was your name? [JESUS *is silent.]*

CENTURION: He is called Jesus of Nazareth.

MARION: Well, have a seat. Mr. Phillips will be with you as soon as possible.

CENTURION: I beseech you, say the word to Lord Phillips. For I also am a man set under authority, having under me soldiers, and I say unto one, Go, and he goeth; and to another, Come, and he cometh.

MARION: And I say unto you, siteth.

ELVIS: [to Centurion] My name's Elvis. Pleasure to meet you. This here is Moses; that's Marion- And that's Solomon, son of David. I didn't quite catch your name, sir,

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CENTURION: I really have no desire to make nice with you people.

ELVIS: [I'm gonna record a song for my mama. Kind of a present. Mr. Phillips says if he can find a white man with the Negro sound and feel, he could make a billion dollars.

CENTURION: Pontius Pilate says the same thing-the nerve! Woman, when will Lord Phillips prepare himself to meet us?

MARION: First of all, I'm not your woman. Second, I wouldn't be your woman if you were the last of the Mohicans. And thirdly- the one with the jumpin' beans in his jeans was here before you.

ELVIS: Well, that's all right, ma'am. *[To Jesus.]* Just doesn't seem proper that I come before you.

JESUS: Suffer it to be so for now.

CENTURION: What's wrong with you? Sideburns here says we can go first. The boy's letting us cut in line. Don't you know that I have the power to crucify you!

JESUS: Thou couldest have no power at all against me, except it were given thee from above.

CENTURION: *[Sitting down.]* My bad.

ELVIS: Are you really Jesus of Nazareth, the Christ, the king of the Jews?

JESUS: I am. [Elvis *is awestruck.]*

MOSES: *[To Jesus]* Jesus Christ. You've always been such a mystery to me. Just exactly what does the "H." stand for?

MARION: Would any of you care for anything to drink?

JESUS: If any man thirst, let him come unto me, and drink.

CENTURION: What are you-running a concession?

ELVIS: You're talking about living water, aren't you?

JESUS: I am the bread of life.

MOSES: You guys are making me hungry.

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CENTURION: *[To Elvis.]* Kid, can I have a word with you? No fraternizing with the accused on my watch, kapeech? This man maketh himself a king, the Son of God.

ELVIS: But he is the Son of God.

CENTURION: *[Beat.]* Get outta here. He is a friend with publicans, tax collectors, and sinners.

ELVIS: That's because they are the ones who need him.

CENTURION: Thou hast proof?

ELVIS: He fed a whole crowd with only five loaves of Wonder bread. He healed the sick, made the blind see, raised the dead.

CENTURION: I thought he was just some freaky long-haired weirdo.

ELVIS: Hardly. *[They return to their seats near Jesus]*

CENTURION: Dude, that crown of thorns thing-sorry.

JESUS: Man, thy sins are forgiven thee.

CENTURION: You're gonna forgive my sins? Lordy, lordy, truly, this man is the Son of God. [Solomon *stands, excited, clutching his latest manuscript.]*

SOLOMON: Hearken unto me! I hath made me a great work! I gave my heart to know wisdom, and I hath found it!

ELVIS: Found what?

SOLOMON: The answer! The answer, my friend. It was blowing in the wind!

MOSES: Oh, if only I had lyrics like that!

ELVIS: Hang loose, man. Let's hear the words of the preacher.

SOLOMON: *[Reading.]* "To every thing there is a season, and a time to every purpose under the heaven. A time to be born, and a time to die. A time to plant, and a time to pluck up that which is planted. A time to kill, and a time to heal; a time to break down, and a time to build up. A time to weep, and a time to laugh; a time to mourn, and a time to dance. A time to cast away

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stones, and a time to gather stones together *[Then, to Elvis.]* How do you like them apples?

ELVIS: Now, that's a pop song!

SOLOMON: You really think so?

ELVIS: I know so. The Byrds will take it to number one.

MOSES: Frogs, flies, pestilence, beetles-now birds!-is there no end!? *[they are interrupted by the buzzer on Marion's phone. She picks up the receiver.]* Yes, Mr. Phillips. Yes, I'll send him in right away. *[Then.]* Mr. Phillips will see you now.

ELVIS: No! Lord, I want to follow you wherever you go.

MARION: Mr. Phillips is waiting. Your whole future is waiting.

ELVIS: *[To Jesus.]* What should I do?

JESUS: Peace be unto you. As my Father hath sent me, even so send I you.

ELVIS: But you're sending me to do what? What is my purpose? Solomon, I need wisdom.

SOLOMON: Rejoice, O young man, in thy youth; and walk in the ways of thine heart.

ELVIS: Mo?

MOSES: I have set before you life and death, blessing and cursing: therefore choose life.

ELVIS: I guess "Love thy neighbor" isn't too far off from "Don't Be Cruel." [*Elvis takes his guitar, straps it on, and strolls toward center stage. He bows his head for" a moment, then looks back at Jesus.*] [Elvis *strums the intra and sings the song "Dear Jesus" (Words and music by Jay Huling.)]*

ELVIS: Dear Jesus, I don't understand, Why did you have to go away? You were a friend to hoodlums, harlots, and thieves, Sinners just like me. To the poor and the meek, The humble and weak, You opened up your loving arms. You gave a damn for the damned; Every woman and man, Sinners just like me. [*CHORUS]*

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When all the finger-pointers were pointing at you, You said forgive-they know not what they do. Love your enemies, And learn to turn the cheek; Give and it will be given you.

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